

University Students' Perceptions of AI Fortune-Telling: An Exploratory Research on Credibility and Motivations

Introduction

Recently, the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) technology with traditional fortune-telling has generated “AI fortune-telling”, which has become increasingly popular among university students. On the lifestyle app RedNote, the hashtag #DeepSeekFortune had over 47 million views by late September 2025. Many university students share their experiences about how to use DeepSeek to calculate Bazi (the eight characters in traditional Chinese fortune-telling, which represent a person's information on birth).

Compared with the high threshold of traditional fortune-telling, AI fortune-telling is much more accessible for young people and are considered to be more accurate (Lai & Zhou, 2023, p. 522). Existing studies have deeply investigated the relationship between traditional fortune-telling and AI (Davies, 2024; Nikolić, 2023, p. 143) and explored the credibility and motivations behind university students' fortune-telling behaviors (Wang & Tai, 2025, pp. 72-73; Dong, 2010, p. 886).

There is a noticeable gap in empirical studies on how university students perceive the credibility of AI fortune-telling and their primary motivations using it.

Therefore, this study aims to fill these gaps by conducting an exploratory research into university students' perceptions of AI fortune-telling, centering on their views of the credibility of AI fortune-telling services, and motivations behind their engagement.

Literature Review

In past years, many researchers paid much attention to the behavior of university students using traditional fortune-telling or divination. Wang and Tai (2025) pointed out that university students use divination tools (e.g. Tarot cards) to ease uncertainty and insecurity, though they clearly realized Tarot cards cannot predict the future (p.72). And Dong (2010) showed that most online fortune-telling seekers are college students. They were enthusiastic about online fortune-telling, but did not fully accept the results of it (p. 86). However, Tarot cards and online fortune-telling still belong to traditional fortune-telling, and they did not take new technology (AI fortune-telling) into account. These studies also failed to accurately describe their level of trust in relevant fortune-telling methods. They focused more on the reasons for fortune-telling enthusiasm than detailed motivation analysis.

Another research stream explores the relationship between traditional fortune-telling and AI technology. Both Davies (2024) and Nikolić (2023) argued that AI and some aspects of fortune-telling or divination, such as Bazi and astrology, are associated as “epistemological frameworks”. These theoretical studies lay a foundation for verifying the credibility of AI

fortune-telling methodologies and prove the feasibility of AI fortune-telling.

Few studies investigated Chinese young people's views on AI fortune-telling. For example, Lai and Zhou (2023) claimed that they prefer AI fortune-telling methods over traditional ones (p. 522). However, these findings lack the demographic focus on university students and overlook the motivation for young people to choose AI fortune-telling.

Though previous work studies university students' views on traditional fortune-telling, their perceptions of AI fortune-telling technology remain under-explored. While some research touches on AI-human relationships through fortune-telling among Chinese young people, the demographic focus on university students is lacking. To fill these gaps, this research will investigate university students' perceptions of AI fortune-telling, centering on their credibility of AI fortune-telling services, and the motivations behind their engagement.

Research Questions

1. How do university students perceive AI fortune-telling?
2. What are the major motivations that drive university students to use AI fortune-telling tools?
3. To what extent do university students believe in the accuracy and reliability of AI fortune-telling?

Methods

1. Participants

This study will recruit a minimum of 100 university students to guarantee an adequate sample size. To ensure an unbiased view, they will be selected randomly from different regions, majors and years of study. Participants will be divided into two groups based on whether they have used AI fortune-telling tools.

2. Data collection

Data will be collected through questionnaires and interviews. The questionnaire intends to collect data on the credibility of participants in AI fortune-telling. Additionally, it aims to gain an initial understanding of participants' perceptions on AI fortune-telling, as well as the motivations of those who have used AI fortune-telling tools. The questionnaire will contain four sections: 1) basic participants' details; 2) usage habits (via multiple-choice questions); 3) motivation measurement (with a Likert scale); 4) perceived credibility assessment (also with a Likert scale).

After collecting the data, semi-structured interviews will be held with 3-5 students who have used AI fortune-telling tools. Each will last approximately 10 minutes in a quiet

discussion room. Interviews will cover: 1) previous AI fortune-telling experiences; 2) motivations for using AI fortune-telling tools; 3) perceptions on the AI fortune-telling predictions. All interviews will be face-to-face, audio-recorded and anonymized.

3. Data analysis

For the quantitative data in questionnaires, they will be processed using Python for data cleaning and organization. Pie charts will show the percentage distribution of usage frequency, preferred tool types and other topics. The Likert-scale data concerning motivation and credibility will be analyzed through descriptive statistics and reliability tests to identify driving factors and trust levels.

For the qualitative data in interviews, the recordings will be transcribed into texts. After examining transcripts, the content will be categorized into different patterns related to students’ AI fortune-telling experiences. These themes will be analyzed to gain deeper insights into motivations and perceptions, supporting the quantitative findings.

Timeline	
Anticipated Activities	Period
Searching literature and proposing the research topic and research questions	September 7 th - September 25 th
Finishing the introduction and literature review part	September 26 th – October 4 th
Completing the research proposal	October 5 th – October 11 th
Designing questionnaires and collecting data	October 12 th – October 30 th
Conducting interview	November 1 st – November 14 th
Analyzing data	November 15 th – November 19 th
Writing research paper	November 20 th – December 12 th

Significance of Research

This research bridges the academic gap between AI fortune-telling and the psychology of university students. With the quantification of motivation and credibility in AI fortune-telling, this study will contribute to the existing literature on digital literacy, mental health, and the ethical design of AI. Findings from this study will help educators and counselors keep up with emerging trends that may influence students’ decision-making and coping with stress and, therefore, may help them provide better guidance in this respect.

(Total Words: 997)

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****Acknowledgment Statement****

I acknowledge that I have used AI-powered writing tools, such as ChatGPT, in writing the assignments.

1. I used DeepSeek and Tencent Yuanbao to help with the literature search on “literature review” part. This AI found out article “Dang dai qing nian ren re zhong wang luo mi xin de she hui xue fen xi [Sociological analysis of contemporary young people’s enthusiasm for Internet superstition]” and “The spiritual dilemmas and solutions of college students’ online astrology: Based on an investigation of the horoscope and Tarot divination behaviors of 2100 college students”.
2. Both DeepSeek and Doubao were used for providing grammar and punctuation guidance. Doubao was specifically asked to identify grammatical errors and offer detailed explanations for them.
3. All these AIs not only helped provide suggestions on expressions, but also served to search for synonyms.